

Florian's early childhood seemed pretty normal by all accounts - he had good friends, a loving family, he played games with the other children that lived around him, he loved going on family outings, he earned high marks in his classes - but appearances are often deceiving, nobody ever truly knows what lies behind the mask that is presented to the outside world/

Florian's once whole and loving family had become fractured as his parents separated when he was 7 years old; his father remarrying quickly did little to help the matter either as the new "mother" in his life did nothing but belittle and scold him, offering next to nothing in the ways of affection and support. The once close, almost inseparable, relationship he held with his father is now practically non-existent as his work left the two with barely any time to see one another - the only consistent time they saw each other being in the mornings before Florian's schooling had begun.

As Florian grew older with each passing year, there seemed to be mounds of pressure piled onto him whether it be from his parents, his instructors, or himself; years of constantly feeling like he'd never be enough, that he'd never be able to please those in his life he so desperately wanted to. His frustration often boiled over into confrontations with others in his class, mostly those who sought to get a rise out of him - which was fairly easy nowadays - the confrontations led to disciplinary action from his instructors which in turn fed the cycle of mental and emotional neglect he was receiving at home.

He spent most of his nights lying awake, staring at the ceiling, wondering what had happened... where it all went wrong... why can't he fix anything... what was wrong with him? He'd look around and see those around him happy and full of life while he sat alone, neglected and isolated; "why can't that be me? why am I not good enough for this?". He poured all of his time in solitude into his studies, mainly his writing of all things, he found it to be a good outlet to vent frustrations and mask his feelings behind characters and plotlines.

This... this is the Florian that is now gone from this world... this is a Florian that has been lost to time, living on only through the memory of a select few... seven long years... that is how long it's been since he was last seen

Florian was 14 years old when he disappeared - the boy who felt the weight of the world on his shoulders, the boy who felt inadequate and isolated, the boy who let his pain fester and grow in cold, isolated silence. He became the "perfect child" seemingly overnight, there was no more complaining, there were no more fights, no... anything, everything just seemed to click but how? Florian had "awoken" the power to bend who he was as a person, to mirror what those around him expected him to be - how ironic that even with the affinity of mirroring, he still awoke with a perceived lesser version of the power - he became the ultimate "yes man" instead of his own man - but maybe, just maybe, there's some power to that in itself

Early Childhood

Florian was the only child his parents, Amelia and Cedric Kristensen, ever had; he was seen as the pride and joy of the family, someone to carry on the family legacy. For the first few years of his life, life couldn't have seemed more perfect to those on the outside looking in; they saw a young couple with a healthy newborn baby boy, they saw a loving and stable familial unit, no tears or anger, just smiles and laughter aplenty. Eventually, cracks in the facade began to show - the family began taking less and less outings together, the ever cheerful Amelia now looked tired and sad when she was seen out; Cedric's warm and caring demeanor towards her had turned cold and distant and it had become VERY apparent within the community that something wasn't quite right.

Age 5

Florian awoke in a sweat, scared awake by yet another nightmare, sadly the waking world wasn't much better than the dream he had just left - he can hear his parents down the hall yelling at one another... again... the yelling almost as familiar to him as his mother's songs at this point. He hesitates to move because he doesn't want them to fight even more, it always becomes a fight when he wakes up in the middle of the night, mommy and daddy blaming each other for waking him up. The volume of this particular argument seemed to grow louder and louder, as if the couple didn't care who heard them anymore.

"YOU WENT TO SEE HER, DIDN'T YOU?!?" Amelia's voice cried out, begging for a response of some sort from her husband... but no answer followed, well, not at first anyway.

"Amelia...", his words stop, as if he were contemplating his next move very carefully, "I would never..." he's cut off by Amelia almost immediately "BUT HERE YOU ARE NOT DENYING A DAMN THING"

Florian decided to get up and quietly walk over to his parents' room, he just wanted them to stop... even for a moment. He makes his way to the door, the old floor slightly groaning under his weight as he goes to peer through the small crack that was always there between the door and the frame.

"Mama", he calls out softly, "can you come sing to me? I had another bad dream." The door opens slowly as Amelia stifles her crying and wipes her eyes well enough to tend to her son "of course dear, I wish I could keep these nightmares away from you", she looks back at Cedric before grabbing Florian's hand as he leads her back to his room for her to sing.

"Mama, it scares me when you and daddy yell, I don't like it." Amelia sighs and forces a smile, "I don't like it either" she says as she caresses his cheek gently before kissing him on the forehead as she stands up to leave. "I love you mama" he says before closing his eyes to sleep.

Amelia looks down at her sleeping son one final time for the evening, tears beginning to well up in her eyes once again, "I love you too, sweet Florian".

Age 7

The last couple of years had been extremely tough at home, the distance between his parents seemed to grow further and further each day to the point where the three of them barely ate dinner together as a full family anymore. Florian now spent most days with friends or with neighbors to avoid the fighting, despite Amelia's and Cedric's "best" efforts to keep it in check and keep life at home civil.

Today was his mother's birthday, he was always excited to celebrate with her even though he couldn't do much for her. He'd always pick a bundle of wildflowers, with the help of some of the neighbors, to give to her - Amelia always made it a point to show how much she appreciated his presents. Florian had woken up extra early to pick an extra big bundle this year as well as get Amelia a piece of berry pie from the bakery (Florian had "worked" for it by helping a couple of times that week as the baker was a family friend); he wanted to make this day extra special for his mom since everything hadn't been for so long.

He arrived home, running excitedly into the house just after midday with the pie and the flowers in hand, ready to give his mom her birthday present. Nothing seemed out of the ordinary, it was outside of Florian crying out with excitement about his surprise "MAMA, MAMA, I GOT SOMETHING FOR YOU". He ran through the house looking for her as she normally would've responded or come looking for him by now having heard him; he decided to check his parents' room to see if she was asleep... and there she was.

Amelia was lying on the bed, eyes closed as if in a deep slumber. Florian ran up to her, attempting to shake her awake "MAMA, MAMA, I GOT YOU A BIRTHDAY PRESENT!"... no response, not even a stir.

"Mama... mama... mama..." he continued to shake her, "mama, you're cold, I'll go get you a blanket." Florian did as he promised and grabbed the blanket off of his bed and wrapped it around Amelia, "I love you mama, I'll take care of you".

Hours passed as day eventually bled into night and Cedric finally arrived home where he met Florian in the kitchen who was sitting in the hallway between the bedrooms. "Mama's been sleeping all day, she must be really tired because I couldn't wake her earlier."

Cedric, looking puzzled, walked into the room and attempted to wake her similarly to how Florian did earlier and then all that was said was one word: "no...". Cedric emerged from the room, his face completely drained of color, tears streaming down his face as he kneels down and hugs Florian tightly as tears continue to flow down his face... "mama's gone to a better place, son."

The funeral was two days after as Cedric rushed to have preparations made, the service was only attended by Cedric and Florian, along with a select few who could show up at such short notice. "Happy birthday mama... I picked these for you", he says as he sets the bundle of flowers, now slightly withered, on her grave "I love you." And then he sat there... motionless,

crying, singing the lullaby his mother used to sing him, the lullaby he'll never get to hear her sing again.

Age 7 (Three months after Amelia's death)

"I don't wanna go" pouted Florian as the wedding was just mere minutes away from beginning

It had only been 3 months since his mother's death, 3 months since he found her, 3 months since he said goodbye...

"I know you don't but it is your father's wedding, you have to be there" replies Bailey, the family friend who owns the bakery in town. "We have to put on a brave face and get through the day"

"Fine" he mutters softly under his breath.

The wedding was nothing special, the most simple ceremony imaginable: just Cedric, Bailey, Florian, & Selene - the bride to be. The nature of the ceremony was not a mistake, Cedric knew how it would look – there were rumors years before the death of Amelia and this marriage has all but confirmed them - the only reason Bailey was here was because somebody needed to help keep an eye on Florian and she has been a trusted family friend since before he was born.

Age 10

Florian came home with yet another black eye, it's the third time this year that this has happened.

"What are you doing that keeps getting you into fights?" scolded Selene. Florian just sat there, no response to give; he knew what he wanted to say, he had told her the same thing the previous two times but she didn't believe him - why would she believe him now?

"Are you just gonna sit there or are you going to give me an answer?" pressed Selene. "I've told you before, you don't believe me... you never believe me." She sighs, "I just find it very hard to believe that you keep getting into these fights and you are NEVER the one at fault." Florian doesn't bother to dignify her with anything resembling a response, he just brushes past her as he starts towards his room; Selene reaches out and grabs him "YOU'RE GOING TO GIVE ME A REAL ANSWER."

Florian tries to shake off her grip "LET GO OF ME!!", his face red and burning with anger. Selene's grip eventually relents as Florian runs off to his room at the first moment he feels the grip break. After making it to his room, he adjusts his sleeve so he can see where Selene had grabbed him - just as he suspected, the imprint of her hand is very prominent on the upper part of his arm, and it looks like her nails had begun to dig in at one point... it wasn't the first time, just another bruise to add the various marks and scars that he's picked up over the years; his father never them, Selene never cared, these were Florian's to bear and bear alone.

As the late afternoon bled into the night, Florian could hear Selene and his father having a long conversation about him, something that has become more commonplace recently as the amount of fights had increased. Eventually, the door to his room creaked open and in stepped Cedric.

“Are we going to talk about today, Florian?” His words were met with silence as Florian did not want to have another argument, he was 10 years old for crying out loud this is a life he had no business living. Cedric sits down on the edge of the bed and lets out a tired sigh “what’s going on kid? Why all the fighting?” Florian sniffles a little and sits up to look at his dad, “the older kids were saying things about mom and you and Selene... you always told me to defend myself.”

Cedric looks up at Florian and then looks away from him almost just as quickly, “there comes a time where fighting is not worth it, sometimes you just have to walk away even if it is the difficult thing to do, sometimes you just have to put on a brave face and control those emotions as best as possible.”